# Used-Car Test-Drive & Inspection Checklist

*Ten calm minutes of looking and listening that can save you thousands.*

## What this is

A print-and-fill checklist for shopping used cars, private sale or dealer lot. It won't replace a mechanic's inspection — it's the first, free, 20-minute filter that most people skip.

## How to use it

1. Print a copy per car you're seriously considering. Fill the top with the year/make/model/price.
2. Page 2: the look-over, on the lot, before you even drive.
3. Page 3: the test-drive with a co-pilot when possible (four ears beat two).
4. Score honestly. Two or more red circles = walk away or price your way in.

**Reminder:** your strongest single move: **pay an independent mechanic $100–150 for a pre-purchase inspection** on any car you'd actually buy. No seller who's honest will refuse. Also run the VIN through a history-report service (CARFAX or the NMVTIS alternatives) yourself.

**Printing tips:** bring a pen on a string or one that clips to the clipboard. Cold engines hide problems — ask to see it cold-start if the seller lets you arrange things that way.

# Used-Car Look-Over — Before the Drive

Car: _____ Seller: _____ Asking: $_____

- [ ] Odometer recorded: _____ (and photo taken)
- [ ] Title available, in seller's name, matches who you're talking to — title lien line clear (“clean title”)
- [ ] Walk around level ground: car sits even (a corner riding low hints suspension or a sway bar)
- [ ] Tires: even wear side to side; same brand pair front/rear; no steel belts showing
- [ ] Panel gaps: consistent lines hood/doors/fenders (wavy gaps can hint a crash repair)
- [ ] Paint: same tone everywhere in daylight (masking-tape “color shift” is a respray clue)
- [ ] Rust: look at wheel wells, door bottoms, and under the tailgate/rockers
- [ ] Lights: every bulb outside works, lenses not fogged-to-mud
- [ ] Under the car where parked: any drips, spots, or puddle stains
- [ ] Engine bay (engine off & cool): no cracked belts, hoses feel pliant not crunchy, oil cap not milky
- [ ] Open all four doors, hood, trunk: all open and latch without fighting
- [ ] Seats/belts/airbag light: belts pull and retract; airbag light ON = hard pass
- [ ] Check ALL warning lights **light up at key-on, then go off** (a dead cluster bulb this close to sale is rarely innocent)
- [ ] Trunk: spare tire present + inflated, jack/tools present
- [ ] Ask for records: any service history? Manual in glovebox?
- [ ] Ask your age question: how many owners, any crashes, any flood claim? (Write answers)

**Verify with your manual:** if the sale happens, the same day, pull the maker's official owner's-manual PDF (free) and note this model's known service intervals + PSI — you'll want page 1 of the maintenance schedule filled in from it.

# Used-Car Test-Drive

Engine cold at start if possible. Plan ~15 minutes: slow streets, one highway ramp, one parking lot.

## Start-up (before you even drive)

- [ ] Cold start: fires quickly, settles to a calm idle — no shaking, revving, or dieseling
- [ ] Interior: no fuel, rotten-egg, or burning smells at idle
- [ ] Under the hood after start: no hissing or ticking that doesn't fade
- [ ] Rear view camera + screens: work (they're expensive modules)

## While driving

- [ ] Accelerates smoothly, no hesitation or shudder
- [ ] Transmission shifts without clunks, slips, or high-rev “lag”
- [ ] Brakes: firm pedal, straight stop, no grind or squeal
- [ ] Steering: wheel straight on level road; car doesn't wander
- [ ] One hard-ish stop: no pulling sideways, ABS doesn't trigger on dry road
- [ ] Full-lock turn both ways (parking lot): no clicking or binding up front (FWD especially)
- [ ] Bumps and seams: one thud per bump — not clunks, rattles, or double-hits
- [ ] At highway speed: no droning (bearings), no vibration in wheel or seat
- [ ] Turn off radio for part of the drive and just listen
- [ ] HVAC runs hot and cold, fan makes no leaf-blower noises
- [ ] After the drive, engine off: fluid smells, steam, or fresh drip under the car?

## Verdict, honestly scored

| TOP 3 THINGS I'D PAY A MECHANIC TO CHECK | OFFER PRICE IF I PURSUE: $ | PURSUE? YES / NO / MORE-INFO |
|---|---|---|
| | | |

**Verify with your manual:** even a healthy-seeming used car hides history — a paid pre-purchase inspection and a VIN history report say what the test-drive can't. Checklist first, receipt second, sale third.